Signal Estimate

Quick briefing

A signal estimate organizes known and assumed factors, compares courses of action and recommends how to meet signal support requirements.

Know the facts

METAL · Mission, Enemy signal capabilities, Troops available, Area of Operations and Logistical requirements.

Known facts and assumptions · Record both where relevant and revise the estimate when the situation changes or new facts emerge.

Situation and courses of action · Annex A covers terrain, weather, existing communications, opposing and friendly situations, and the proposed courses of action.

Analysis and comparison · Examine what the opposing and friendly capabilities and limitations mean for support, then compare the courses of action under the same mission conditions.

Decision and recommendations · State recommendations for personnel, communications capabilities, sustainment and tasks so the commander can make a decision.

Understand the reasoning

An estimate should make its controlling assumption visible. If an option relies on an unconfirmed support team, availability of that team can change the recommendation.

Comparing options on the same requirements reveals tradeoffs such as continuity, staffing effort and sustainment rather than simply ranking equipment.

Philippine Army classroom exercise

During a fictional Philippine Army evacuation tabletop, one communications option supports every simulated relief desk but needs an extra operator. A second supports the priority desks with staff already assigned. The extra operator’s arrival remains uncertain.

Decision · What recommendation should the signal planner make for the start of the exercise?

Worked analysis · Recommend the staffed option if it meets the priority desks’ minimum requirements. Document reduced service to the other desks and set confirmation of the extra operator as a point to reconsider the broader option. This keeps the commander’s decision tied to the actual personnel assumption.

How to practice

1 · State the support mission and the decision the estimate must inform.

2 · Use METAL to organize known facts, assumptions and information gaps.

3 · Describe each course of action and examine how exercise conditions and capabilities affect support.

4 · Compare options on the same mission requirements and identify the assumptions that could change the result.

5 · Record the recommended option and its personnel, communications and sustainment implications. Revise it when key facts change.

Check yourself

In METAL, what do T and L stand for? · Troops available and Logistical requirements.

Where in Annex A are tradeoffs across options brought together? · Comparison of COAs, before Decision and Recommendations.

Course source

PAM 6-0102 · Signal Operations